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AL-QAEDA QUEERS THE PITCH

September 11 began as just another day for Lashkar. As occurred with regularity, its militants were engaged in firefights with Indian security forces.[1] On the day al-Qaeda launched the deadliest ever terrorist attacks against America, Lt. Gen Mahmud Ahmed, the Director-General of the ISI, was on Capitol Hill in Washington, DC deflecting US entreaties to persuade the Taliban to hand over Osama bin Laden. The day after the attacks, US Deputy Secretary of State Richard Armitage summoned General Ahmed and Pakistani Ambassador Maleeha Lodhi. Foreshadowing the speech US President George W. Bush planned to give later that night, Armitage told General Ahmed and Ambassador Lodhi that Pakistan was either with America or with al-Qaeda.[2] Armitage and Secretary of State Colin Powell compiled a list of what the US demanded from Pakistan, which was presented to General Ahmed on 13 September. By the afternoon Pervez Musharraf, who had taken power in a bloodless military coup in 1999 and assumed the office of the presidency in summer 2001, had agreed to American demands. The US embassy in Islamabad reconfirmed Musharraf's agreement the following day, but added that Musharraf had indicated he would pay a domestic cost and needed to show Pakistan would benefit from the decision.[3] The Clinton Administration had taken a tough line with Pakistan throughout the 1990s, including the imposition of additional sanctions, and the country was in its fourth year of recession by 2001. Musharraf requested an end to sanctions as well as immediate economic relief. Within weeks the Bush Administration lifted sanctions on Pakistan and began channeling aid to the country.[4]

Backing the Taliban had been a cornerstone of Pakistan's regional security policy in the 1990s and was driven by the hope that it would